

- RAG Learning

3.1 Liberalism

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 3 (Political Ideas)

Liberalism is the dominant ideology of the modern Western world — so pervasive that its assumptions are often mistaken for common sense. Its central value is **individual freedom**, and its internal history is the story of a single disagreement: whether freedom is best secured by *restraining* the state or by *using* it.

Specification requirement. AQA names **six key thinkers** for liberalism — note that this is one more than for conservatism and socialism, and that T.H. Green is frequently omitted by students: **John Locke, Mary Wollstonecraft, John Stuart Mill, T.H. Green, John Rawls** and **Betty Friedan**.

1. Core ideas

Individualism

The individual is the central unit of moral and political value. Society exists to serve individuals, not the reverse, and is best understood as a collection of individuals rather than an organic whole. Two forms:

- **Egoistical individualism** — individuals are self-interested and self-reliant; associated with classical liberalism.
- **Developmental individualism** — individuals have potential to fulfil, which society should help them realise; associated with Mill and modern liberalism.

Freedom

The supreme political value — but contested:

- **Negative freedom** — the absence of external constraint. A person is free to the extent that no one prevents them acting.
- **Positive freedom** — the actual capacity to act and develop. Poverty, ignorance and ill health are constraints even where no one interferes.

Rationalism

Human beings are capable of reason, so they can identify their own interests better than any authority can. This is the premise from which almost everything else follows: consent, rights, toleration, free expression and democracy all depend on it. It is also liberalism's most vulnerable claim.

Equality and social justice

- **Foundational equality** — all individuals are born with equal moral worth and equal natural rights.
- **Formal (legal) equality** — equality before the law; no legal privilege.
- **Equality of opportunity** — a fair starting point, with unequal outcomes accepted as legitimate where they reflect effort and talent. Liberals reject equality of *outcome*.

The state

Necessary but dangerous. Locke argued that in the state of nature rights exist but are insecure, so a state is needed to adjudicate impartially — yet because it holds coercive power it is also the chief threat to liberty. Hence **constitutionalism**: limited government, the rule of law, separation of powers, checks and balances, and government by consent.

Liberal democracy — with reservations

Liberals support democracy as most compatible with consent and accountability, but are wary of unconstrained majority rule. Mill's fear of the **tyranny of the majority** explains the liberal insistence that democracy be constrained by protections for minorities and individual rights.

2. Key thinkers

John Locke (1632–1704) — *Two Treatises of Government* (1689)

- **Natural rights** — to life, liberty and property, existing prior to and independently of government.
- **State of nature** — unlike Hobbes's, it is tolerable but *inconvenient*: rights exist but there is no impartial judge to resolve disputes.
- **Social contract and consent** — government is legitimate only where it rests on the consent of the governed.
- **Fiduciary (trust) power** — government holds authority *in trust* for the people. If the trust is broken, they may withdraw it — a right of rebellion.
- **Limited government** — with separated powers and the rule of law.

Mary Wollstonecraft (1759–1797) — *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792)

- **Women are rational** — the apparent inferiority of women results from denied education, not from nature.
- **Formal equality** — if rights derive from rationality and women are equally rational, denying them rights is inconsistent with liberalism's own foundations.
- **Education** as the route to independence and genuine citizenship.
- **The "revolution controversy"** — she defended the French Revolution's principles against Burke, arguing that reason and rights, not inherited tradition, should found political authority.

Exam Tip: Wollstonecraft demonstrates liberalism's **radical internal logic**. She did not attack liberalism — she convicted it of inconsistency with itself. The same argument was later extended to other excluded groups, which is why liberalism has been an engine of extension despite starting from a narrow base.

John Stuart Mill (1806–1873) — *On Liberty* (1859)

- **The harm principle** — the only legitimate ground for restricting liberty is to prevent harm to others. A person's own good is never sufficient warrant, which rules out state paternalism and the legal enforcement of morality.
- **Freedom of expression** — even a false opinion is valuable, because truth held without being contested becomes dead dogma.

- **Tyranny of the majority** — democratic majorities and social opinion can oppress dissenters as effectively as any despot.
- **Developmental individualism** — human beings are progressive beings capable of growth, and individuality should be cultivated.
- **The bridge** — his defence of negative freedom is classical; his developmental strand pointed towards modern liberalism.

T.H. Green (1836–1882)

- **Positive freedom** — freedom is the actual capacity for self-development, not merely the absence of interference.
- **The enabling state** — because poverty, ignorance and ill health are themselves constraints, state action to remove them *expands* liberty rather than restricting it.
- **Social liberalism** — individuals are socially embedded and have obligations to one another; a modified view of the atomised individual.

John Rawls (1921–2002) — *A Theory of Justice* (1971)

- **Justice as fairness** — principles of justice are those that would be chosen under fair conditions.
- **The original position and veil of ignorance** — choosers do not know their own class, talents, gender, race or conception of the good.
- **First principle:** equal basic liberties for all.
- **The difference principle:** social and economic inequalities are justified only where they work to the greatest benefit of the *least advantaged*.
- **Reasoning:** rational self-interested choosers behind the veil would not risk being at the bottom of a harshly unequal society.

Betty Friedan (1921–2006) — *The Feminine Mystique* (1963)

- **Cultural conditioning** — women were constrained not primarily by law but by socialisation persuading them that domesticity should fulfil them: "the problem that has no name".
- **Equal rights and opportunity** — access to education, careers and public life on the same terms as men; she co-founded the National Organization for Women.

- **Liberal, not radical** — she sought women's inclusion in existing structures rather than their transformation, which is precisely why later feminists criticised her.

3. Strands of liberalism

	Classical liberalism	Modern liberalism
Freedom	Negative — absence of interference	Positive — capacity for self-development
Individualism	Egoistical	Developmental
The state	Minimal "night-watchman" — state action is inherently a restriction of liberty	Enabling — education, healthcare, welfare expand freedom
The economy	Laissez-faire; free markets as an expression of individual choice	Managed capitalism; Keynesian demand management; regulation
Equality	Formal and legal equality	Substantive equality of opportunity requiring redistribution
Thinkers	Locke, Wollstonecraft, Mill (partly)	Green, Rawls, Friedan

Neo-liberalism is a twentieth-century revival of classical liberal economics — free markets, deregulation, privatisation, a minimal state — which fed into the New Right. Note that it belongs to the *classical* lineage, not a development of modern liberalism.

4. Tensions and debates

Disagreement	One side	The other
What freedom means	Locke, Mill — absence of constraint	Green, Rawls — capacity to act

Role of the state	Minimal; state action reduces liberty	Enabling; state action expands liberty
Distributive justice	Nozick (from a liberal premise) — just acquisition and transfer; redistribution violates self-ownership	Rawls — inequalities justified only where they benefit the least advantaged
Society	A collection of self-sufficient individuals	Individuals socially embedded and mutually obligated (Green)

Exam Tip: The key analytical point: **classical and modern liberals share the same ultimate value and reach opposite conclusions.** Both prioritise individual freedom; they disagree about what freedom *requires*. That is why liberalism contains both the welfare state and its fiercest critics, and why "is liberalism coherent?" is a live question.

The Berlin objection

Isaiah Berlin warned that **positive freedom** is dangerous: it permits others to define what a person's "real" interests are and to coerce them accordingly, in the name of their own liberty. This is the argument Nozick develops against redistribution — and it means the concept that rescued liberalism from irrelevance also opened it to the charge of licensing the very paternalism Mill rejected.

5. Is liberalism coherent?

The charge: classical and modern liberalism disagree about the state, the economy and equality so fundamentally that they cannot be one ideology.

The reply: all liberals share individualism, rationalism, foundational equality, the primacy of freedom, constitutional and limited government, and toleration. The disagreement is about *means*, and follows logically from a genuine ambiguity in the concept of freedom itself. Compared with conservatism — which contains both Burke's inherited obligation and Rand's rational egoism — liberalism is the more internally consistent tradition.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Individualism	The individual as the central unit of political and moral value
Negative freedom	Absence of external constraint
Positive freedom	The actual capacity to act and fulfil one's potential
Egoistical individualism	Individuals as self-interested and self-reliant
Developmental individualism	Individuals as having potential society should help realise
Natural rights	Rights existing prior to and independently of government
Social contract	The notional agreement by which individuals consent to government
Fiduciary power	Government holding authority in trust for the people (Locke)
Harm principle	Liberty may be restricted only to prevent harm to others (Mill)
Tyranny of the majority	Majority opinion oppressing dissenting individuals
Veil of ignorance	Device for choosing principles of justice without knowing one's own position
Difference principle	Inequalities justified only where they benefit the least advantaged
Meritocracy	Position determined by talent and effort rather than birth
Mechanistic theory	The state as a human construct created to serve individuals